Forklift



Category: **Retail, Logistics & Warehouse** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 8 labs

Covers these lab items: Fork Lift; Fork lifts; Forklift etc

What it is used for

A forklift lifts, carries, and places palletised or approved loads in warehouses and other work areas. Correct load handling, operator training, and controlled driving help prevent tip-over, collisions, and crushing injuries.

Main parts

- Forks support and lift the load.
- Mast guides the forks vertically during lifting and lowering.
- Hydraulic system powers lifting and tilting functions.
- Operator seat or platform provides the designated operating position.
- Steering wheel or control handle directs the forklift.
- Service brake and parking brake control stopping and stationary holding.
- Overhead guard and seat belt, where fitted, help protect the operator.

Before you start

1. Only a trained and authorised operator may use the forklift.
2. Complete the required pre-use inspection according to the operator's manual.
3. Check tyres, forks, mast, chains, hydraulics, brakes, steering, lights, horn, and alarms.
4. Confirm the load weight, load centre, and forklift capacity from its rating plate.
5. Ensure the route is clear, the floor is stable, and overhead clearance is sufficient.
6. Wear the seat belt where fitted and adjust the seat and controls before moving.

How to use

1. Mount the forklift using the designated steps and maintain three points of contact.
2. Start the forklift according to the manufacturer's instructions and check controls.
3. Keep forks low and tilt the mast as recommended while travelling without a load.
4. Approach the load slowly and align the forks with the pallet openings.
5. Insert the forks fully and evenly under the load before lifting.
6. Raise the load only enough to clear the floor and tilt it back as instructed.
7. Travel at a controlled speed with the load low and visibility maintained.
8. Use a spotter or approved travel direction when the load blocks forward visibility.
9. Stop on level ground, lower the load fully, and position it securely before withdrawing the forks.
10. Park in the designated area, lower the forks, apply the parking brake, and switch off.

⚠ Safety

- Never exceed the rated capacity or carry unstable, unsecured loads.
- Never allow anyone to stand or walk beneath raised forks or a lifted load.
- Do not carry passengers unless the forklift is specifically designed for them.
- Avoid sharp turns, sudden braking, and travel on slopes beyond the manufacturer's limits.
- Keep hands and feet inside the operator area and away from the mast.
- Never use the forklift to lift people unless an approved personnel platform and procedure permit it.

Care & storage

- Park safely and report defects before the forklift is returned to service.
- Check fluid leaks, tyres, forks, chains, and safety devices during routine inspections.
- Keep the operator area, steps, and controls clean and free from loose objects.
- Arrange scheduled servicing and battery or fuel-system maintenance through authorised personnel.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Travelling with forks raised too high or a load too high.
- Lifting a load without checking its weight and the forklift rating plate.
- Turning quickly or driving too fast in narrow or crowded areas.
- Parking without lowering the forks, applying the parking brake, or switching off.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.

Prepared by - Subodh Kumar